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# Only one of 13 lawmakers came to affordability hearing

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In December, Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas said affordability should be the California Legislature's top priority.

In April, his office announced they'd be creating four select committees targeting high cost drivers in California. At the time, Rivas spokesperson Nick Miller said the committees were "strategic" and "not performative."

One of those committees, the Select Committee on Child Care Costs, met for the second time Wednesday at Burbank City Hall.

Of the 13 members, only one showed up: Committee Co-chair Cecilia Aguiar-Curry, D-Winters.

Aguiar-Curry held court for over three hours, hearing from state agencies as well as child care providers and the organizations and unions that work with them.

She asked questions about how child care systems are integrated into emergency planning efforts, and heard testimony from local providers, already cash-strapped, about how they were affected financially by the LA wildfires.

Child care is one of the largest cost drivers for families in the state. According to the Public Policy Institute of California, "the full-time cost of preschool care is 6 percent to 18 percent-and infant care is 8 percent to 28 percent-of median incomes."

Four of the lawmakers on the committee represent districts in the Los Angeles area, where the meeting was held: Assembly members Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, Sharon Quirk-Silva, D-Fullerton, Pilar Schiavo, D-Chatsworth, and Jose Solache, D-Lakewood. Staff from Gabriel and Schiavo's offices said the lawmakers couldn't attend due to previous commitments. Quirk-Silva and Solache's offices didn't respond to a request for comment.

Rivas also declined to comment. Miller said member schedules are impacted during recess, and it's important to keep the process going.

Aguiar-Curry echoed the sentiment, sharing in an emailed statement that the state "can't afford to lose momentum."

Panels during the interim study recess don't normally draw a large crowd, but this month's panels on public safety, sea level rise and the economy, and fisheries and aquaculture drew larger crowds.

Cristina Alvarado, executive director of the Child Care Alliance of Los Angeles, spoke at the hearing and said in an interview afterward that she appreciated having an "intimate" audience with Aguiar-Curry, because it made people more comfortable.

Regardless, as a long-time advocate, she said she's used to an unpredictable audience.

"Sometimes we get unlucky and we have one or two legislators showing up at a committee meeting where there's people testifying, and sometimes the whole committee is there."

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